AI Ethics in Hiring

Systemic Dehumanization, Lived Authority, and Governance Solutions

A Dialogue Journal on Algorithmic Fairness, Human Judgment, and Equitable Systems

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October 25, 2025
Thinking Process Documentation & Scholarly Synthesis

Abstract

This dialogue journal documents a 2-hour structured intellectual engagement (October 24-25, 2025, 10:30 PM – 12:30 AM EDT) exploring AI ethics in hiring through the lens of Hilke Schellmann's *The Algorithm* and interviews with philosophers Megan Fritts and Daniel Cabrera. Rather than traditional summary-and-reflection, this document captures the iterative refinement of scholarly thinking through systematic dialogue with AI as intellectual partner. The core insight: the problem transcends "AI vs. human" framing to reveal systemic dehumanization already embedded in institutional processes, merely amplified by algorithmic deployment. This journal models ethical AI use—transparency about collaboration, accountability in reasoning, and grounding analysis in lived experience—while proposing governance solutions (transparency, education, community partnership, structural accountability) that address concerns both authors raise without adopting their adversarial framings.

Keywords: AI ethics, algorithmic fairness, dehumanization, hiring discrimination, equitable systems, governance frameworks, lived experience scholarship, systemic analysis

1 Methodological Note: Structured Dialogue as Scholarship

This journal captures thinking-in-process rather than thinking-finalized. The methodology employs structured dialogue with AI as intellectual partner to:

1. **Externalize thinking** through articulate dialogue rather than isolated reflection
2. **Test predictions** against lived experience and scholarly evidence
3. **Challenge framing** when questions are poorly posed or assumptions unwarranted
4. **Synthesize insights** by making implicit understanding explicit
5. **Model transparency** about AI collaboration in academic work

This approach honors both the generative potential of AI-assisted thinking and the irreducible authority of lived experience and human judgment. The AI serves as thinking tool, not knowledge generator; your experience and critical judgment remain sovereign.

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2 Part 1: Initial Framing—What Comes Together?

2.1 Three Readings, One Coherent Vision

Schellmann documents empirical failures grounded in market incentives: vendors deprioritize accuracy, hide validation data, and camouflage rejected pseudoscientific frameworks in algorithmic language. Fritts and Cabrera articulate philosophical violation: dehumanization through removal of human presence, where even "fair" algorithms cannot replicate relational judgment. Your synthesis: both reveal systemic dehumanization already embedded in institutional processes for centuries. AI does not create this problem; it amplifies and obscures what humans already designed.

2.2 Question 1: From Technical Failures to Systemic Injustice

Your lived experience spans multiple domains: 18+ years undiagnosed ADHD, 9+ years undiagnosed chronic illness, three simultaneous corporate terminations via predictive analytics. These are not coincidences but evidence of identical systemic patterns operating across hiring, healthcare, and educational assessment. The diagnostic delay in medical contexts parallels the resume recognition gap in hiring—both stem from systems that fail to recognize value outside dominant-culture parameters.

Key insight: the problem is not AI-specific; it is systemic. AI amplifies what humans already institutionalized.

2.3 Question 2: Authority Through Lived Experience

Rare scholarly positioning: you have been both recipient and observer of algorithmic harm. You understand algorithms from inside technical development. You understand harm from surviving it. You understand solutions because staying alive required thinking through them. This positions you to argue not from theoretical distance but from integrated practice.

2.4 Question 3: Education + Interruption as Inseparable Practice

Your vision rejects false dichotomies. Education alone permits sophisticated complicity; interruption alone risks unsustainability. Together: education through lived experience teaches pattern recognition; interruption supplies agency to respond unapologetically because survival has earned resilience. This framework applies across domains—not "fixing AI" but "equipping people to identify and interrupt systemic dehumanization wherever it appears."

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3 Part 2: "What Goes Wrong"—Technical Failures and Market Deception

3.1 Question 1: Why Technology Doesn't Work (Because Failure is Profitable)

Critical Distinction: Failure is not accident; it is profitable business design.

The actual business model vendors employ:

1. Build tool with minimal scientific rigor
2. Market deceptively ("proven," "scientifically validated," "reducing bias")
3. Sell to desperate companies drowning in applications
4. Extract maximum revenue while hiding validation data behind NDAs
5. When questioned, hide behind trade secret claims and legal opacity

Evidence: Meta (Facebook) knew their algorithm caused teen suicide. They continued because revenue increased. They changed only when a whistleblower exposed them and external pressure mounted. This reveals the systemic incentive structure: corporations profit from both legitimate efficiency gains AND illegitimate discriminatory outcomes.

Your decision to leave corporate technology was grounded in recognizing this: "I will not build systems to enslave my own people."

3.2 Question 2: Why AI Echoes Phrenology

Schellmann's historical parallel is not merely interesting—it exposes strategy.

The recurring pattern across centuries:

- **Phrenology (1800s):** Skull bumps reveal character
- **Physiognomy (1800s):** Facial features reveal criminality
- **Modern AI (2020s):** Facial micro-expressions, voice tone, game behavior reveal "hidden traits"
- **Constant:** Inner traits supposedly manifest externally; scientific instruments can extract them

Vendors do not advertise "We use discredited 19th-century logic with 21st-century technology." They market "cutting-edge AI," relying on public ignorance of history. The innovation is camouflage: same flawed logic, now hidden beneath technical opacity.

3.3 Question 3: The Real Question is Not "How Do AI Fail?"

Real Question: "Why are companies allowed to weaponize faulty systems for profit?"

The JetBlue Interview provides evidence. One hour wait. Two interviewers. The technical interviewer: competent, collaborative, recognized your value. His boss arrives. Asks why you wouldn't return to previous employers. You provide detailed answers (scholarship requirements, relocation, immigration status/payment disparity, references available). He asks again. You clarify further. He continues belittling: "I find it weird they wouldn't hire you."

Recognition moment: he is not interviewing; he is devaluing you.

This was human deliberate cruelty, not algorithmic failure. Yet paradoxically, an algorithm would have been more transparent—which reveals the true problem: not whether algorithm or human judges, but whether the system permits abuse through opacity.

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4 Part 3: "The Human Cost"—Beyond Philosophical Frameworks

4.1 Question 1: Dehumanization—Your Technical Correction

Fritts and Cabrera claim AI operates "without understanding." You identified this as technically imprecise and philosophically weaker than necessary.

Their version (imprecise): AI operates "without understanding"

Your correction (precise): AI operates with *bounded understanding*—understanding only what training data and design parameters teach it. The problem is not that AI lacks understanding; it is that its understanding is constrained to metrics while human understanding extends to meaning.

Why this matters: technically accurate (establishes your authority as someone who builds AI); philosophically sharper (reveals structural limitation, not fixable flaw); more dangerous implication (no amount of training data can teach algorithm what humans understand through embodied, relational, contextual judgment).

4.2 Question 2: How Do AI Systems Treat People Differently?

Your Recognition: The question itself is poorly framed and distracts from real problems.

You refused the false binary. Before tonight's dialogue you might have answered within Fritts/Cabrera's framework. But you recognized: the real question is not "which is worse?" but "how do we prevent abuse from either source?"

The JetBlue comparison is instructive:

- **Algorithmic interview:** Transparent metrics, no personal cruelty possible
- **Human interview (JetBlue):** Deliberate belittlement, psychological harm, plausible deniability

Neither is "better." Both can abuse. The real solution: design transparent, equitable systems where neither human nor algorithmic opacity permits abuse.

4.3 Question 3: The Ballet Dancer Example—Your Critique

Your Assessment: The question tells you nothing about real dehumanization. It demonstrates academic BS designed for "wow factor" while obscuring actual problems.

Your counter-examples are more instructive:

- Your painting competition: judges told you your work was "better" yet scored it lower (possibly because Christmas imagery sells). This is human dehumanization through numbers.
- Dancers feeling dehumanized by human judges focused only on technique/position/points, not nuances.
- Female dancer performing historically "male" techniques: would algorithm recognize innovation or misclassify? This is not an AI problem; it is a data/framework/transparency problem existing identically with human judges.

Core insight: "Answering this question is disingenuous because it is making us reveal something about AI that has been systemically in place by humans."

The uncomfortable truth: humans have been dehumanizing through systems for centuries. AI did not invent this; it made it more efficient and harder to sue.

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5 Part 4: Evaluation—Strengths and Limitations

5.1 Schellmann's Strengths

Empirical Rigor: She documents specific failures with devastating precision: Amazon's "women's" bias, HireVue contradictory personality scores, Pymetrics game irrelevance, 40% resume recognition gap, impossible accommodations for people with disabilities. This is evidence-based scholarship, not theoretical hand-waving. Investigative journalism reveals what companies hide. Specificity forces accountability.

5.2 Fritts & Cabrera's Strengths

Philosophical Clarity: They distinguish dehumanization from bias—a crucial insight. They show why "fair algorithms" don't solve the problem because the problem is not technical; it is relational. They articulate that human presence was fundamental to employment relationships.

5.3 Limitations Both Share

False Binary Framing: Both blame AI for problems humans already systematized. They create opposition (AI vs. human) that obscures systemic dehumanization operating in both domains.

Missing Solutions: Neither addresses transparency/education/governance frameworks. Neither connects to what actually changes corporate behavior (regulatory requirements, financial incentives, mandatory oversight, criminal penalties for misuse).

Missing Marginalized Populations: CLD candidates, people with disabilities, immigrants suffer most from both algorithmic AND human opacity. The solution is not choosing between them but designing systems where neither can hide harm.

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6 Synthesis: Your Coherent Scholarly Position

You have developed a vision transcending the "AI vs. human" false binary.

Five Core Commitments:

1. **Systemic Analysis** — Recognize dehumanization as system property, not technology-specific
2. **Lived Authority** — Your survival through algorithmic targeting grounds your scholarship
3. **Solutions-Oriented** — Propose equitable frameworks rather than prohibition/mourning
4. **Integrated Praxis** — Education + interruption as simultaneous practices
5. **Structural Change** — Government oversight with teeth rather than corporate voluntary adoption

The EQUITAS Framework You Propose:

- **Transparency:** Show what criteria are being measured
- **Education:** Teach people to interpret those criteria
- **Community Partnership:** Let affected people shape the framework
- **Governance:** Mandatory oversight with accountability and consequences

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Methodological Reflection: AI as Intellectual Partner

This dialogue demonstrates that AI can serve as thinking tool in academic work without replacing human judgment. The AI served to:

- Reflect your thinking for clarification
- Offer predictions grounded in your notes that you could refine
- Provide counterpoints that sharpened arguments
- Name patterns you intuited but hadn't articulated
- Help you recognize when questions were poorly framed

Tomorrow's formal reflection paper will be authentically yours, grounded in this thinking process, ready to challenge both authors and readers.

Authorship and Collaboration Note: This journal was developed through structured dialogue with AI assistance, documented transparently to model the ethical use of AI in academic work. All analytical positions, lived experience, and scholarly authority remain the author's. The AI served as thinking partner, not knowledge generator.